

The Hong Kong Polytechnic University

Subject Description Form

Subject Code	ENGL1A29
Subject Title	Mastering Persuasion for the Workplace
Credit Value	3
Level	1
Pre-requisite/ Co-requisite/ Exclusion	Exclusion: ENGL1A26 [Remarks: ENGL students may take this subject.]
Objectives	This course aims to empower students with a toolkit of communication strategies to navigate, influence, and lead effectively and successfully in their future professions. To achieve this aim, students will master the psychology of persuasion and the art of professional rapport. By uncovering how language impacts human behaviour, students will be able to understand others better and express themselves more accurately, confidently, tactfully, and persuasively in the workplace.
Intended Learning Outcomes <i>(Note 1)</i>	Upon completion of the subject, students will be able to: a) develop a strategic and creative edge in mastering essential business genres in the workplace, allowing them to navigate business reports, persuasive speeches, and oral presentations with professional maturity; b) prepare and deliver high impact oral business presentations that captivate and engage a professional audience; c) compose and deliver persuasive messages confidently and effectively in professional contexts; d) use English confidently and adaptively in different business communicative situations in Hong Kong and global contexts; and e) Fulfil the CAR reading and writing requirements in English.
Subject Synopsis/ Indicative Syllabus <i>(Note 2)</i>	The subject can be divided into two parts. Part I builds students' professional foundation by unlocking the psychological secrets of influence and the linguistic mechanisms of social interaction. Part II provides students with ample opportunities to apply these

	concepts in real-world professional simulations, transforming and applying the theories learnt in Part I to various business genres. Part I – The Science of Professional influence (1) Concepts and theories of persuasion - Aristotle means of persuasion - Elaboration likelihood model - Reasoned action approach - Cognitive dissonance theory - Extended parallel process model (2) Concepts and theories of pragmatics and genres - Politeness, rapport and rapport management - Business genres (e.g. oral presentations, business reports, managerial responses) Part II – Career Application (1) Spoken genres - Persuasive speeches - Business oral presentations (2) Written genres - Managerial responses - Business reports																								
Teaching/Learning Methodology <i>(Note 3)</i>	Adopting a highly practical, learner-centred approach, the subject will be taught through dynamic and interactive lectures and seminars. The lectures will focus on the introduction and discussion of concepts and theories, and presentation and analysis of authentic data taken from the business/professional contexts. The seminars will provide students with ample opportunities to test these concepts and theories, to discuss the applicability of these concepts and theories in various workplace situations and scenarios, and to reflect critically on the way people use language in interactions in modern workplaces.																								
Assessment Methods in Alignment with Intended Learning Outcomes <i>(Note 4)</i>	<table border="1"> <tr> <th rowspan="2">Specific assessment methods/tasks</th><th rowspan="2">% weighting</th><th colspan="5">Intended subject learning outcomes to be assessed (Please tick as appropriate)</th></tr> <tr> <th>a</th><th>b</th><th>c</th><th>d</th><th>e</th></tr> <tr> <td> </td><td> </td><td> </td><td> </td><td> </td><td> </td><td> </td></tr> </table>						Specific assessment methods/tasks	% weighting	Intended subject learning outcomes to be assessed (Please tick as appropriate)					a	b	c	d	e							
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1. Group presentation	30%	✓	✓	✓	✓	
2. Written Assignment – Draft 1	20%	✓		✓	✓	✓
3. Written Assignment – Draft 2	30%	✓		✓	✓	✓
4. Class participation	20%	✓	✓	✓	✓	
Total	100 %					

Explanation of the appropriateness of the assessment methods in assessing the intended learning outcomes:

The group presentation assesses intended learning outcomes (a), (b), (c), and (d). It provides students with an opportunity to prepare and deliver a 15-minute oral business presentation as a group. This provides students with an opportunity to apply the concepts and theories learnt in working with their peers as they will need to persuade and manage rapport with others while working as a group.

The written assignment (Draft 1 and Draft 2 – 1500 to 2500 words) assesses intended learning outcomes (a), (c), and (d). The written assignment transforms students into strategic consultants who read, analyse, and interpret a data file. This provides an opportunity for students to demonstrate understanding and mastery of the newly acquired concepts and theories of pragmatics, genres, and persuasion. This assignment is delivered in two drafts: Draft 1 consists of a detailed plan of a report guided by a template and questions provided by the subject instructor; and Draft 2 is written based on the first stage and consists of the finalised report.

Class participation assesses intended learning outcomes (a), (b), (c), and (d). It includes weekly in-class and out-of-class activities. These activities reinforce the understanding of the concepts and theories of linguistics and psychology, generate critical discussion, and create new perspectives on professional workplace communication.

	Fulfilling the ER & EW requirements: ER: Students will need to read the recommended texts before they are able to complete Assessment 2 & 3. The total number of pages of these five sources is more than 200. EW: Please refer to Assessment 2 and 3 above. Students must obtain a D or above on the written assignment to pass the course.	
Student Study Effort Expected	Class contact:	
	▪ Lectures	26 Hrs.
	▪ Seminars	13 Hrs.
	Other student study effort:	
	▪ Reading	40 Hrs.
	▪ Preparation for assignments	30 Hrs.
	Total student study effort	109 Hrs.
Reading List and References	Required Readings (258 pages): Allchin, C. (2021). <i>Communicating with data: Making your case with data</i> (1st ed.). O'Reilly. (Extracts from chapters 1-10, 50 pages) Perkins, P. S., & Brown, L. (2008). <i>The art and science of communication: Tools for effective communication in the workplace</i>. John Wiley & Sons, Incorporated. (Extracts from chapters 1-5, 7, 30 pages) Perloff, R. (2021). <i>The dynamics of persuasion: Communication and attitudes in the twenty-first century</i> (7th ed.). Routledge. (Chapter 1 (17 pages) - Chapter 2 (31 pages) - Chapter 12 (27 pages) - Chapter 13 (31 pages)) Shirley, K. (2009). <i>Contemporary business report writing</i> (4th ed.). Cengage Learning. (Chapter 4 (33 pages) - Chapter 11 (16 pages) – Chapter 12 (23 pages))	

	Further Readings: Adler, N. J., & Gundersen, A. (2007). <i>International dimensions of organizational behavior</i> (5th ed.). Cengage Learning. Cialdini, R. B. (2021). <i>Influence, new and expanded: The psychology of persuasion</i>. Harper Business. Evans, S. (2010). Business as usual: the use of English in the professional world in Hong Kong. <i>English for Specific Purposes</i> 29(3), 153-167. Gass, R. H., & Seiter, J. S. (2026). <i>Persuasion: Social influence and compliance gaining</i> (8th ed.). Routledge. O’Keefe, D. J. (2003). Message properties, mediating states, and theoretical explanation: Confidence, content, and compliance in persuasive message effects. <i>Communication Theory</i>, 13(3), 251-274. O’Keefe, D. J. (2016). <i>Persuasion: Theory and research</i> (3rd ed.). Sage. Stiff, J. B., & Mongeau, P. A. (2016). <i>Persuasive communication</i> (3rd ed.). The Guilford Press. Trompenaars, F., & Hampden-Turner, C. (2020). <i>Riding the waves of culture: Understanding diversity in global business</i> (4th ed.). Nicholas Brealey.
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Revised by Azar Tajabadi, May 2026